

THE SLOW ATLAS

Thailand

The Complete Guide

Where to go, what to eat, and how to travel it slowly.



A SLOW ATLAS GUIDE • VOLUME I

WELCOME

Sawatdee – welcome

There is nowhere quite like Thailand. In one trip you can wake to mist over northern mountains, ride a scooter past golden temples, eat the best meal of your life from a plastic stool on a side-street, and fall asleep to waves on a southern shore. It is dazzling, warm, deeply hospitable — and wonderfully easy to travel.

This guide is built to help you travel slowly and well: to understand the country, plan with confidence, and leave room for the unplanned afternoons that become the best memories. Everything you need is here — from your first visa question to your last bowl of noodles.

WHAT'S INSIDE

- Before you go — timing, paperwork, health & packing
- Budget — what it really costs, with sample spends
- Destinations — the unmissable places, region by region
- Four ready-to-use itineraries, 7 to 14 days
- Getting around — a transport map, driving & scooter hire
- Where to stay, what to eat, what to do
- Culture, safety, responsible travel & a phrasebook

HOW TO TRAVEL IT SLOWLY

- Choose one or two regions, not all four.
- Build in empty days — Thailand rewards lingering.
- Eat where the locals queue; say yes to the unfamiliar.
- Learn ten words of Thai; you'll be met with warmth.
- Move on the ground to see the country in between.
- Travel kindly — to people, animals and the land.

LOCAL TIP

Keep a little cash, a smile and an empty afternoon in your pocket — Thailand fills them better than any plan.



PART ONE

Before you go

Timing, paperwork, health and packing – sorted.



IN THIS PART

When to go & festivals

Documents, health & money

What to pack

THE SLOW ATLAS

When to go

OI

Choosing the right window matters more in Thailand than almost anywhere — and the north and south often run on different clocks.

Cool & dry

NOV – FEB

The sweet spot: clear skies, cool hill evenings. Peak season — book ahead, especially over New Year.

Hot

MAR – MAY

Fierce heat (35–40°C); Mar–Apr brings crop-burning haze to the north. Songkran (13–15 Apr) is a water-fight new year.

Green & wet

JUN – OCT

Warm monsoon — short, heavy bursts rather than all-day rain. Lush, quiet, cheap; the Andaman coast is wettest.

A MONTH-BY-MONTH ALMANAC

MONTH	WEATHER	DON'T MISS
Jan	Cool, dry, ideal	Peak season
Feb	Warm, dry	Flower festival
Mar	Hot, N. haze	Islands shine
Apr	Hottest	Songkran
May	Hot, first rains	Low season
Jun	Warm, wet spells	Green & cheap

MONTH	WEATHER	DON'T MISS
Jul	Monsoon	Buddhist Lent
Aug	Wet in places	Quiet north
Sep	Heavy rains	Lowest prices
Oct	Rains ease	Veg. festival
Nov	Cool returns	Loy Krathong
Dec	Cool, busy	High season

Documents, health & money

ENTRY & VISAS

- Many nationalities (EU, UK, US, Australia, Canada...) enter visa-free for short stays — the exact number of days changes, so confirm the current rule for your passport before you fly.
- Passport valid 6+ months beyond arrival, with blank pages.
- Have proof of onward travel & accommodation ready.
- Longer/multiple-entry stays: arrange the right visa in advance.
- Never overstay — fines are charged per day at the airport.

HEALTH & VACCINATIONS

- See a travel clinic 6–8 weeks ahead for current advice.
- Routine jabs up to date; Hepatitis A & typhoid often advised.
- Dengue is mosquito-borne — repellent dusk & dawn.
- Insurance is essential — and **MUST** cover motorbikes if you'll ride.
- Tap water isn't safe; bottled or filtered only.

MONEY

- The baht (THB) is cash-first outside cities; carry small notes.
- ATMs everywhere but charge ≈THB 220 per foreign withdrawal — take more, less often.
- Cards work in malls, hotels & chains; markets are cash only.
- Tell your bank you're travelling; carry a backup card, stored apart.
- Tipping isn't expected; rounding up is kind.

CONNECTIVITY

- Tourist SIM (AIS, TrueMove, dtac) at the airport, or an eSIM before you fly.
- Data is fast & cheap; coverage excellent outside deep mountains.
- Save offline maps for road trips.

LOCAL TIP

Three things change most often — visa length, prices and opening hours. Re-check them on the official sites a few days before you fly.



What to pack

03

Thailand is hot, humid and casual — pack light, in natural fabrics, and leave room for what you'll buy. Laundry is cheap and everywhere, so a week's clothes is plenty.

CLOTHING

- Light, loose, quick-dry clothes
- One set covering shoulders & knees (temples)
- A light layer for cool northern evenings
- Swimwear + a sarong (modesty, beach, picnic)
- Walking sandals + trainers
- A packable rain jacket

HEALTH & ESSENTIALS

- High-SPF, reef-safe sunscreen + sun hat
- Insect repellent (DEET) & after-bite
- First-aid kit, rehydration salts, your meds
- Hand sanitiser & tissues
- Universal adapter & power bank
- Refillable water bottle

DOCUMENTS TO CARRY (PAPER + DIGITAL COPIES)

- Passport, visa, insurance details
- Driving licence + International Driving Permit (if driving)
- Card details & emergency numbers stored offline
- A few passport photos for any on-the-spot paperwork

LOCAL TIP

In the wet season, a THB-20 plastic poncho from any 7-Eleven beats the smartest rain jacket — buy one and stash it under your seat.



PART TWO

Budget

What it really costs – and how to travel for less.



IN THIS PART

Daily budgets, low to lavish

A sample two-week spend

Prices to anchor on

THE SLOW ATLAS

What Thailand costs

Thailand suits every budget. You can travel beautifully on very little, or indulge for a fraction of European prices. Here's what to expect per person, per day, on the ground.

STYLE	PER DAY	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Backpacker	THB 900–1,500	Hostels & fan rooms, street food, scooters, public transport
Comfort	THB 2,500–4,500	Smart guesthouses & 3+ hotels, restaurants, some flights & tours
Boutique	THB 6,000+	Design hotels & resorts, private drivers, spas, fine dining

SAMPLE 2-WEEK COMFORT BUDGET

ITEM	THB
Accommodation (13 nights)	16,000
Food & drink	9,000
Transport & 1–2 flights	7,000
Activities & tours	6,000
Scooter / car & fuel	3,500
SIM, extras, buffer	3,500

≈ THB 45,000 · about €1,150 / £980 / \$1,250

PRICES TO ANCHOR ON

- Street meal: THB 50–80
- Restaurant main: THB 120–250
- Local beer: THB 70–100
- Coffee: THB 50–80
- Scooter hire: THB 200–300/day
- Litre of petrol: ≈THB 40
- Guesthouse double: THB 600–1,200
- Domestic flight: THB 1,000–2,500
- Train (2nd class): THB 200–900
- Day tour: THB 800–1,800

PART THREE

Destinations

The unmissable places, region by region.



IN THIS PART

The lie of the land

Bangkok · Chiang Mai · the South

Which island is for you?

Ayutthaya, Kanchanaburi & Isaan

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The lie of the land

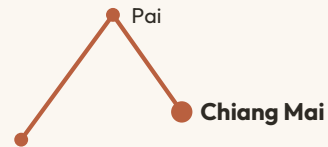
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Thailand falls into four broad regions. Don't try to cover them all — choose one or two and travel slowly.

The North

Mountains, Lanna temples, hill tribes, the best road trips and cool air. Chiang Mai, Pai, Mae Hong Son.

Mae Hong Son



The Centre

Bangkok's energy, ancient Ayutthaya, the River Kwai, beaches at Hua Hin. The hub you'll arrive in.

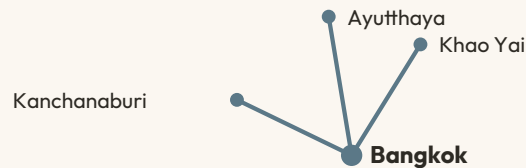
Isaan (NE)

Khmer ruins, silk villages, the Mekong, fiery food, few tourists, big welcomes.

The South

Two coasts of islands, karsts and rainforest. Phuket, Krabi, Khao Sok, Koh Lanta, the Gulf isles.

● Isaan



INSIDER TIP

Each region has its own colour on the map opposite — and its own pace. Link two at most, ideally with a short internal flight, and let the road in between be part of the trip.



Schematic — not to scale

Thailand's electric capital is a city of contrasts: glittering temples beside neon malls, river life beside skytrains, and some of the best street food on earth. Give it two or three days — it grows on you fast.

DON'T MISS

- Grand Palace & Wat Phra Kaew (Emerald Buddha)
- Wat Pho's reclining Buddha & a temple massage
- Wat Arun at sunset, from across the river
- A long-tail boat through the Thonburi canals
- Chatuchak weekend market — 15,000 stalls

EAT & DRINK

- Pad krapow & boat noodles from street stalls
- Chinatown (Yaowarat) after dark for seafood & sweets
- Mango sticky rice from a market cart
- A rooftop bar for the skyline (smart-casual)

GOOD TO KNOW

- Dress modestly for temples (shoulders & knees).
- The river and canals are half the magic — ride them.
- It's hot and huge — plan around the midday heat.
- Base near the river (Old Town) or a BTS station.

GETTING THERE & AROUND

- Two airports (BKK & DMK); the Airport Rail Link into town.
- BTS Skytrain + MRT metro are fast, cheap & cool.
- River boats & Grab to dodge the traffic.
- A great hub for trains & flights everywhere.

Chiang Mai & the North

The laid-back cultural capital of the north — a moat-ringed old town of 300 temples, fringed by mountains, cooking schools and coffee. The gateway to Pai, Mae Hong Son and the great northern road trips.

DON'T MISS

- Old-city temples — Wat Chedi Luang & Wat Phra Singh
- Doi Suthep temple, on the mountain above town
- An ethical elephant sanctuary (no riding)
- A cooking class & the Sunday Walking Street
- Pai & the Mae Hong Son Loop (see itineraries)

EAT & DRINK

- Khao soi — the north's coconut-curry noodles
- Sai ua (herby sausage) & nam prik dips
- Khao niao (sticky rice) with everything
- Locally grown northern coffee

GOOD TO KNOW

- Cool, especially Nov–Feb; pack a light layer.
- Avoid Mar–Apr burning season (smoky air).
- Rent a scooter to explore the valley.
- Yi Peng & Loy Krathong (Nov) fill the sky with lanterns.

GETTING THERE & AROUND

- A 1-hour flight or overnight sleeper train from Bangkok.
- Compact old town — walk or cycle it.
- Scooters & songthaews for the outskirts.
- The launchpad for the northern loop.

The South & islands

Postcard Thailand: limestone karsts rising from turquoise seas, rainforest national parks, and an island for every mood. Two coasts mean there's almost always somewhere dry.

DON'T MISS

- Railay & Ao Nang (Krabi) — climbers' cliffs & beaches
- Phang Nga Bay by long-tail or kayak
- Khao Sok National Park — jungle lake & raft-houses
- Koh Lanta — long, mellow west-coast beaches
- Ko Tao — world-class, cheap diving

EAT & DRINK

- Fresh seafood grilled by the beach
- Southern curries — rich, turmeric-gold, fiery
- Massaman — mild and fragrant
- Fruit shakes & fresh coconut

GOOD TO KNOW

- Andaman coast: best Nov–Apr. Gulf: Feb–Apr & Jul–Aug.
- Ferries link the islands; book ahead in high season.
- Reef-safe sunscreen only — protect the coral.
- Quiet beaches reward those with a scooter.

GETTING THERE & AROUND

- Fly to Phuket, Krabi or Ko Samui, then ferry on.
- Long-tails & speedboats for island hops.
- Scooters rule on the islands themselves.
- See 'Which island?' to choose your base.

Which island?

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Thailand has hundreds of islands across two coasts. Here's how the best-loved ones compare, so you can match the island to your mood.

ISLAND	COAST	VIBE	BEST FOR
Phuket	Andaman	Big, busy, every comfort	Easy access, resorts, nightlife
Koh Lanta	Andaman	Long, mellow beaches	Families, slow couples, sunsets
Railay / Ao Nang	Andaman	Karst cliffs by the sea	Climbing, dramatic scenery
Koh Phi Phi	Andaman	Beautiful but party-busy	Young travellers, day trips
Koh Samui	Gulf	Polished resort island	Comfort, flights, families
Koh Pha-ngan	Gulf	Jungle & Full-Moon Party	Beach life + nightlife
Koh Tao	Gulf	Small, laid-back	Cheap, world-class diving
Koh Chang	East	Big, forested, quieter	Nature, fewer crowds

WHEN TO GO WHERE

Andaman coast (Phuket, Krabi, Lanta): driest Nov–Apr. Gulf coast (Samui, Pha-ngan, Tao): best Feb–Apr & Jul–Aug. If one coast is wet, the other is often fine – that's the beauty of two seas.



A short history & the arts



A TIMELINE, IN BRIEF

Early kingdoms — Dvaravati & strong Khmer influence (10th–12th c.) — the temples of Isan.

Sukhothai, 13th c. — The first Thai kingdom; a golden age of art and the Thai script.

Ayutthaya, 1351–1767 — A powerful, cosmopolitan capital, razed by the Burmese.

Bangkok, from 1782 — The Chakri dynasty; Siam alone in Asia was never colonised.

Today — A constitutional monarchy, and a creative boom in design & film.

DID YOU KNOW?

Bangkok is home to Michelin-starred street-food stalls — pavement cooking here is treated as an art, not a last resort.

HERITAGE TO SEEK OUT

- Bangkok's wats: Pho, Arun & the Emerald Buddha.
- The UNESCO ruins of Ayutthaya & Sukhothai.
- Chiang Mai's Lanna temples & Doi Suthep.
- Isan's Khmer sanctuaries — Phimai & Phanom Rung.
- Jim Thompson House — silk, art & a mystery.

THE LIVING SCENE

- Creative districts (Charoenkrung, Bangkok).
- Auteur cinema — Apichatpong's Palme d'Or.
- Craft that's still made by hand: ceramics, weaving, lacquer.
- Festivals that light the calendar (see When to go).

LOCAL TIP

Pair a temple at dawn with a museum at noon: Thailand reveals itself fastest through its sacred spaces and its makers.



Ayutthaya, Kanchanaburi & Isaan

Beyond the headline sights lies a quieter, history-rich Thailand — easy add-ons from Bangkok, or a route all their own.

DON'T MISS

- Ayutthaya — the romantic ruins of the old capital
- Kanchanaburi — the River Kwai & Erawan Falls
- Khao Yai — waterfalls, gibbons & vineyards
- Phimai & Phanom Rung — Khmer temples older than Angkor
- The Mekong towns & surreal Sala Keoku

EAT & DRINK

- Som tam (green-papaya salad) — Isaan's icon
- Larb & gai yang with sticky rice
- Sai krok Isan — sour fermented sausage
- Mekong river fish, simply grilled

GOOD TO KNOW

- Ayutthaya: rent a bike to ride between the temples.
- Kanchanaburi: an easy, lovely long weekend from Bangkok.
- Isaan: little English, the warmest welcomes, lowest prices.
- Trains & buses link it all; a car reaches the villages.

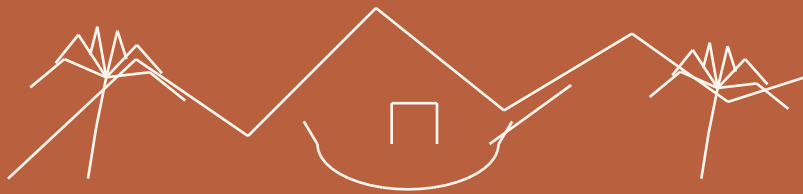
GETTING THERE & AROUND

- Ayutthaya: 1–1.5 h by cheap local train from Bangkok.
- Kanchanaburi: 2–3 h by train or minivan.
- Isaan: sleeper trains & buses from Bangkok.
- Best explored slowly, with your own wheels.

PART FOUR

Ready-to-use itineraries

Four trips, planned for you – adapt and go.



IN THIS PART

7 days · a first taste

10 days · the North

12 days · islands & south

14 days · best of Thailand

THE SLOW ATLAS

7 days · First-timer's taste



Can only spare a week? This loops Bangkok, the old capital and the cultural north for a perfect first bite of Thailand.

D1-2 Bangkok

Grand Palace, Wat Pho, a canal boat and Chinatown street food.

D3 Ayutthaya day-trip

Cycle the romantic ruins of the old capital.

D4 Fly to Chiang Mai

Sunset at the night bazaar.

D5-6 Chiang Mai

Old-city temples, a cooking class and an ethical elephant visit.

D7 Doi Suthep & home

Mountain temple, a last massage, then fly out.



MAKE IT YOURS

Add 3-4 days and an island flight to turn this into a two-week trip.

Schematic — not to scale

10 days · The North

12

Mountains, temples and the legendary Mae Hong Son Loop, from a Chiang Mai base. Fly in and out of Chiang Mai. Best Nov–Feb.

D1–2 Chiang Mai

Old-city temples, a cooking class, an ethical elephant visit and the night markets.

D3 To Pai

Ride the 762 curves north; waterfalls and coffee stops.

D4 Pai

Canyon at dawn, hot springs, white temple at sunset.

D5 To Mae Hong Son

Tham Lod cave and the bamboo bridge; a calm Shan town.

D6 Mae Hong Son

Ban Rak Thai tea village and misty viewpoints.

D7 To Mae Sariang

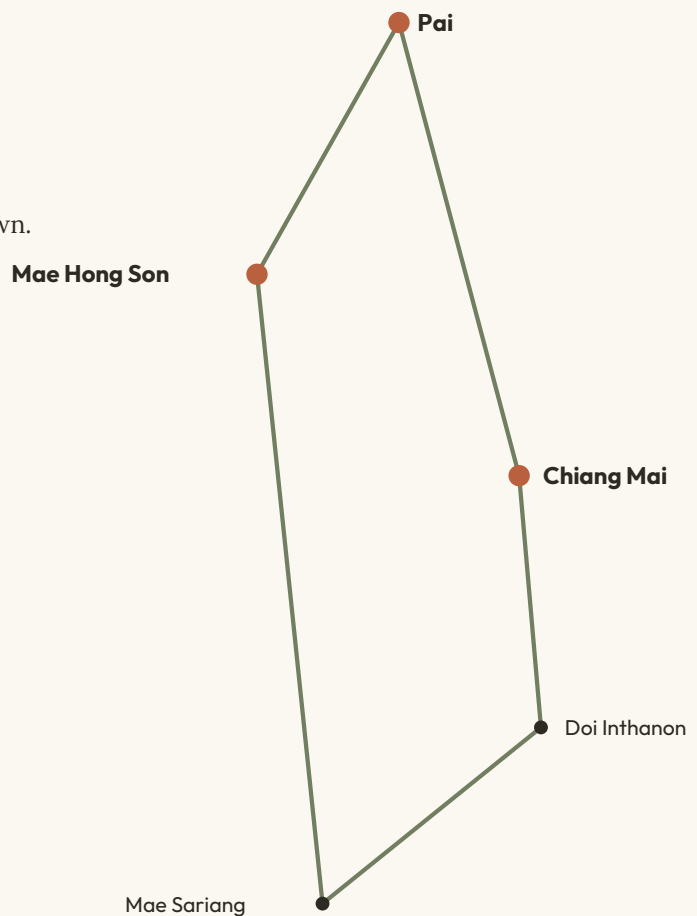
A quiet riverside town on the loop's western arm.

D8 To Doi Inthanon

Thailand's highest peak; twin pagodas and waterfalls.

D9–10 Chiang Mai

Massage, markets and a slow finish before flying out.

**MAKE IT YOURS**

Add a 2-day side-trip to Chiang Rai's White & Blue Temples if you have time.

Schematic — not to scale

12 days · Islands & South

13

Karsts, rainforest and beaches down the Andaman coast, finishing island-slow. Fly into Phuket, out of Krabi. Best Nov–Apr.

D1–2 **Phuket**

Old-town shophouses and a first beach; ease into island time.

D3 **Phang Nga Bay**

Long-tail or kayak among the sea-stacks and lagoons.

D4–5 **Khao Sok**

Jungle lake by raft-house; dawn mist and gibbons.

D6–8 **Krabi, Ao Nang & Railay**

Climbers' karsts, beach-hopping and cliff-ringed Railay.

D9–11 **Koh Lanta**

Long, quiet beaches; sunsets and old-town seafood.

D12 **To Krabi & home**

A last swim before the flight out.



MAKE IT YOURS

Swap Koh Lanta for Koh Phi Phi if you want more buzz, or Koh Yao Noi for more quiet.

Schematic — not to scale

14 days · Best of Thailand

14

Bangkok, the cultural north and the southern islands, linked by two short flights. The classic first-timer's grand tour.

D1-3 Bangkok

Temples, river life, Chinatown food and a day-trip to Ayutthaya.

D4 Fly to Chiang Mai

Evening at the night bazaar.

D5-7 Chiang Mai

Temples, cooking class, ethical elephants and Doi Suthep.

D8-9 Pai or the hills

A taste of the mountains — slow and scenic.

D10 Fly south to Krabi

Swap mountains for the sea.

D11-13 Krabi & islands

Railay, Ao Nang and a day among the karsts.

D14 Home

One last Thai breakfast before the airport.



MAKE IT YOURS

Short on time? This works at 10 days by trimming the north to three nights.

Schematic — not to scale

PART FIVE

Getting around

How the country joins up, and how to drive it.



IN THIS PART

The transport network map

Flights, trains, buses & boats

Driving & where to rent a scooter

THE SLOW ATLAS

The transport network

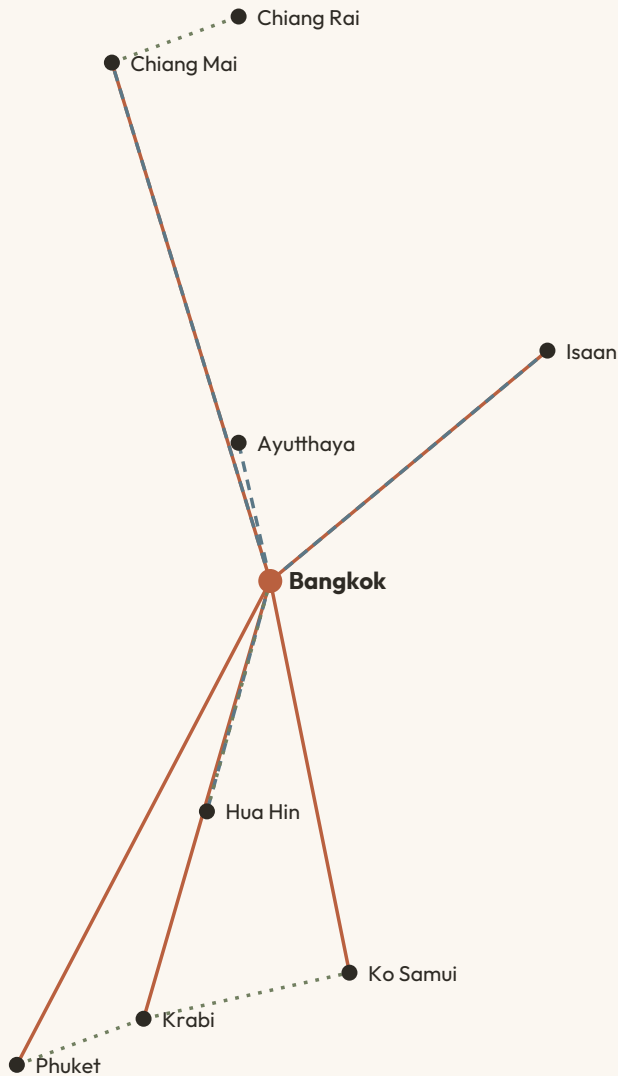
Thailand is superbly connected. Domestic flights are cheap and quick; trains are scenic; buses and minivans reach everywhere; ferries link the islands. This map shows how the main hubs join up.

LEGEND

- Flights — fast, cheap, frequent
- - - Trains — scenic & characterful
- Buses & ferries

RULES OF THUMB

- North to south: fly (1–1.5 h vs 12+ h overland).
- Bangkok–Ayutthaya: hop on a cheap local train.
- The overnight sleeper to Chiang Mai is a classic.
- Islands: fly to the nearest airport, then ferry.
- Book trains, buses & ferries on 12Go.



Modes of transport

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Flights

Cheap and quick with AirAsia, Nok, Thai Lion & Bangkok Airways. Best for north to south. Book ahead for the lowest fares.



Trains

Scenic and social. 2nd-class A/C is comfy; the overnight sleeper to Chiang Mai is a rite of passage. Reserve ahead.



Buses & minivans

Reach everywhere; comfy 'VIP' coaches on big routes. Minivans are faster but cramped.



Ferries & long-tails

Link the islands (reduced in monsoon). Long-tails for short hops — agree the price first.

IN TOWN

- Bangkok: BTS Skytrain + MRT metro — fast, cheap, air-conditioned.
- Grab & Bolt apps for metered, hassle-free rides (pay in-app).
- Metered taxis: insist on the meter. Tuk-tuks: agree the fare first.
- Songthaews (shared pick-ups) run fixed routes for a few baht.
- Motorbike taxis (orange vests) for quick solo hops.

Driving & renting a scooter

THE RULES

- Carry an International Driving Permit + your licence — checkpoints are common and insurance depends on it.
- Drive on the LEFT; give way to bigger vehicles.
- Helmets are law (and life-saving); wear closed shoes.
- Avoid night driving on rural roads.
- Fuel is cheap; fill up before remote stretches.

RENTING A SCOOTER — CHECKLIST

- Choose 150cc+ for mountains; 125cc is fine in town.
- Photograph every scratch with the owner first.
- Never leave your passport as deposit — pay cash.
- Check brakes, tyres, lights; insist on a good helmet.
- Confirm your travel insurance covers motorbikes.

WHERE TO RENT — THE MAIN HUBS

- Chiang Mai & Pai — the northern loop's launchpads; lots of choice.
- Phuket, Krabi & Ao Nang — easy island & coast hire.
- Koh Lanta, Samui, Pha-ngan — scooters rule the islands.
- Sukhothai & Ayutthaya — perfect for touring the ruins.
- Avoid renting in central Bangkok — traffic is brutal; use the BTS.

CAR HIRE

- From ≈THB 900–1,400/day; international desks at every airport.
- Safer for families and the rainy season; air-con is a blessing.
- Take the fullest insurance; photograph the car all round first.

PART SIX

Where to stay & what to eat

From raft-houses to rooftop curries.



IN THIS PART

Accommodation & where to base

How to eat in Thailand

A region-by-region dish glossary

Accommodation

Thailand has some of the best-value beds in the world — from £6 hostel bunks to design hotels that would cost five times more in Europe. Book the first and last nights ahead; improvise the middle.

TYPE	£ / NIGHT	BEST FOR
Hostel / guesthouse	THB 200–700	Backpackers, solo travellers, meeting people
Boutique guesthouse	THB 800–1,800	Character & comfort without the price
3–4★ hotel / resort	THB 1,800–4,500	Pools, breakfast, families
Design / luxury	THB 5,000+	Special occasions, honeymoons
Homestay / raft-house	THB 500–1,500	Villages, national parks, real local life

WHERE TO BASE YOURSELF

- Bangkok: Old Town (river, temples) or Sukhumvit (BTS, food).
- Chiang Mai: inside or just outside the old-city moat.
- Krabi: Ao Nang for access; Railay to wake by the cliffs.
- Islands: west coast for sunsets; quiet beaches need a scooter.

BOOKING TIPS

- Read recent reviews for cleanliness, noise & Wi-Fi.
- A/C vs fan: worth it in the lowlands; fan is fine up north.
- High season & holidays: book well ahead.
- Off-season walk-ins can be bargained — politely.
- Check the map pin, not just the photos.

LOCAL TIP

Many guesthouses are cheaper booked by a quick message or phone call than through an app — and they'll often pick you up from the bus stop.



How to eat in Thailand

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STREET FOOD, DECODED

- The best meals come from carts and tiny shophouses — follow the crowds of locals.
- Many stalls cook one dish brilliantly; point if you can't pronounce it.
- Sit, eat, pay after; a bowl of noodles is THB 50–80.
- Markets cluster at dawn and dusk — arrive hungry.
- Busy + fresh + hot = safe. Watch it cooked.

SPICE & ORDERING

- 'Mai phet' = not spicy; 'phet nit noi' = a little (still a lot!).
- Season at the table: fish sauce, chilli, sugar, vinegar.
- Rice ('khao') is the centre; share dishes family-style.
- Spoon & fork: the fork pushes, the spoon delivers.

VEGETARIAN & ALLERGIES

- 'Mangsawirat' = vegetarian; 'jay' = strict vegan — look for the yellow-red '๑ ๑' flag.
- Fish sauce & shrimp paste hide everywhere — 'mai sai nam pla / kapi'.
- Peanuts are common; carry an allergy translation card.
- The Vegetarian Festival (Oct) is a feast for plant-eaters.

WHAT TO DRINK

- Cha yen — sweet orange iced tea.
- Nam manao — fresh lime soda.
- Fruit shakes ('mai sai nam tan' for no sugar).
- Singha, Chang & Leo — ice-cold local beers.
- Roadside coffee — Café Amazon is everywhere.

What to order · North & Centre

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THE NORTH

Khao soi — the crown — egg noodles in coconut curry, crisp noodles on top

Sai ua — herby grilled Chiang Mai sausage

Nam prik num — smoky green-chilli dip with sticky rice

Gaeng hang lay — rich Burmese-style pork curry

Khanom jeen nam ngiao — rice noodles in tomato-pork broth

Khao niao — sticky rice — eaten by hand

CENTRAL & BANGKOK

Pad krapow — holy-basil stir-fry + fried egg — the comfort dish

Tom yum goong — hot-and-sour prawn soup

Tom kha gai — coconut-galangal chicken soup

Pad thai — the famous wok noodles

Khao man gai — Hainanese chicken & rice

Massaman — mild, fragrant curry of Persian roots

Mango sticky rice — khao niao mamuang — the dessert

LOCAL TIP

Order several small dishes from different stalls and share — that, not a single big plate, is how Thais eat best.



What to order · Isaan & South

18

ISAAAN (NORTH-EAST)

Som tam — pounded green-papaya salad — 'phet nit noi'

Larb — zingy minced-meat salad, herbs & toasted rice

Gai yang — marinated grilled chicken

Sai krok Isan — sour fermented pork sausage

Nam tok — 'waterfall' grilled-beef salad

Khao niao — sticky rice — the staple

THE SOUTH & SWEETS

Gaeng tai pla — intense southern fish curry — for the brave

Khao yam — fresh herbal rice salad

Seafood & massaman — coconut-rich, fragrant, often milder

Grilled seafood — by the beach, with nam jim dip

Roti — griddled banana-and-egg pancake

Tropical fruit — mangosteen, rambutan, durian (if you dare)

MARKET WISDOM

- Morning markets for fruit, coffee & rice dishes; night markets for grills, noodles & sweets.
- A bag of cut fruit with chilli-salt is the perfect THB-20 snack.
- Look for the stall with the longest local queue — always.

Shopping & craft

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WHERE TO SHOP

- Markets — Chatuchak (Bangkok), the Chiang Mai night bazaars.
- Air-conditioned malls — ICONSIAM for a rainy afternoon.
- Village workshops — Isan silk, Lampang ceramics, Bo Sang umbrellas.
- Floating & weekend markets for the theatre of it.

WORTH BUYING

- Thai silk, celadon & lacquerware.
- Curry pastes, spices & dried fruit.
- Teak and bamboo homeware.
- Hill-tribe textiles & cotton clothing.

BUY SMART

- Counterfeits are everywhere — and illegal to import home.
- Bargain with a smile in markets; fixed prices in malls.
- Favour authentic craft over fakes — it lasts and it gives back.
- Check weight & fragility before you commit to ceramics.

AVOID

Exporting genuine antiques or old Buddha images is forbidden without a Fine Arts Department permit — and buying a Buddha head as a 'souvenir' is best avoided out of respect.

LOCAL TIP

The best souvenirs are edible or wearable — curry pastes, silk, a hand-thrown bowl — and they keep the craft alive back home.



PART SEVEN

Experiences & practical tips

What to do – and how to do it well.



IN THIS PART

Things to do, by interest

Culture & etiquette

Safety, scams & responsible travel

A Thai phrasebook

THE SLOW ATLAS

Things to do

CULTURE & SPIRIT

- Temple-hop the great wats — early, modestly dressed.
- Give alms to monks at dawn, respectfully.
- See Loy Krathong & Yi Peng lanterns (Nov).
- Take a Thai cooking class — a half-day highlight.
- A traditional Thai massage (from THB 250/hour).

MOUNTAINS & JUNGLE

- Trek to hill-tribe villages & waterfalls up north.
- Ride the Mae Hong Son Loop by scooter or car.
- Kayak Khao Sok's jungle lake; spot gibbons at Khao Yai.
- Chase waterfalls — Erawan's seven turquoise tiers.

SEA & ISLANDS

- Learn to dive on Ko Tao — famously cheap and good.
- Long-tail or kayak through Phang Nga & Krabi karsts.
- Island-hop by ferry; find a beach with no name.
- Sunset from a long-tail, then seafood on the sand.

WITH ANIMALS — ETHICALLY

- Choose genuine sanctuaries where elephants roam and are never ridden — research first.
- Avoid riding, shows and tiger selfies.
- Watch wildlife in national parks, at a respectful distance.

Culture & etiquette

DO

- Return a 'wai' (palms together) with a smile.
- Dress modestly at temples; shoes off.
- Keep calm; a smile defuses almost anything ('jai yen').
- Give & receive with your right hand, or both.
- Ask before photographing people.

DON'T

- Touch anyone's head — even a child's.
- Point your feet at people or Buddha images.
- Raise your voice or show anger ('losing face').
- Disrespect the monarchy — it's against the law.
- Women: don't touch or hand things directly to monks.

THE IDEAS BEHIND IT

Two words explain a lot of Thailand. 'Sanuk' is the belief that life — even work — should have an element of fun. 'Jai yen', a cool heart, prizes calm over confrontation. And 'mai pen rai' — never mind, it's fine — is a whole gentle philosophy of letting things go.

AT THE TEMPLE (WAT)

- Cover up, shoes & hat off, lower your voice.
- Sit with feet tucked behind you.
- A small donation helps with upkeep.
- Never climb on ruins or Buddha images.

Safety, scams & responsible travel

COMMON SCAMS — SMILE & DECLINE

- 'The temple/palace is closed today' — it isn't; the tout has a gem shop.
- Cheap tuk-tuk 'tours' that detour to commission stops.
- Rigged taxi meters — insist on the meter or agree first.
- Jet-ski / scooter 'damage' claims — photograph everything at pickup.
- Over-friendly strangers with card games or 'free' drinks.

STAY SAFE

- Thailand is generally very safe; petty theft is the main risk.
- Use hotel safes; keep a card & cash separate.
- Respect the sea — heed red flags & rip currents.
- Insurance must cover motorbikes if you'll ride.

TRAVEL RESPONSIBLY

- Refill a bottle — plastic waste is a real problem.
- Reef-safe sunscreen; never touch coral.
- Buy from local markets, kitchens & guides.
- Choose ethical animal experiences (no riding/shows).
- Carry out your litter on remote roads & trails.
- Dress and behave modestly at sacred sites.

EMERGENCY NUMBERS

- Police 191 · Ambulance 1669
- Tourist Police (English) 1155
- Tourism Authority (TAT) 1672

For every traveller

SOLO WOMEN

- Widely regarded as safe and easy; usual night-time sense applies.
- Modest dress is appreciated away from the beach.
- Night transport is reliable — trains, Grab.

REDUCED MOBILITY

- Bangkok improves (BTS lifts, accessible big hotels) but pavements are uneven and temples often have steps.
- Favour newer hotels; confirm access in advance.
- Plan private taxis/transfers; some resorts offer adapted rooms.

LGBTQ+

- Among Asia's most welcoming destinations.
- Visible scenes in Bangkok, Phuket & Chiang Mai.
- Usual discretion in rural and religious areas.

DIGITAL NOMADS

- Fast, cheap internet; superb café & coworking culture (Chiang Mai, Bangkok).
- Check the latest long-stay / remote-work visas before you commit.

BUSINESS

- Districts: Sathorn, Sukhumvit, Silom.
- Exchange cards with both hands; a small gift is appreciated.
- Easy to bolt a few leisure days onto a work trip.

LOCAL TIP

Whatever your profile, the same rule serves you well in Thailand: dress modestly, keep a cool heart, and a smile unlocks the rest.



A Thai phrasebook · I

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ESSENTIALS

Hello — sawatdee (khrap/kha)
Thank you — khop khun (khrap/kha)
Yes / No — chai / mai chai
Please — karuna
Sorry / excuse me — khor thot
No worries — mai pen rai
Do you speak English? — phut angkrit dai mai?
I don't understand — mai khao jai
My name is... — phom/chan chue...

NUMBERS

1 nung · 2 song · 3 sam · 4 si · 5 ha · 6 hok · 7 jet · 8 paet
 · 9 kao · 10 sip · 20 yi-sip · 100 nung roi · 1,000 nung
 phan

GETTING AROUND

Where is...? — ...yu thi nai?
How much? — tao rai?
Too expensive — phaeng pai
Turn left / right — liao sai / liao khwa
Straight on — trong pai
Stop here — jort thi ni
Bus / train station — sathani rot / rot fai
Petrol station — pam nam man
Toilet — hong nam

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AT THE TABLE

Delicious! — aroi!**Not spicy, please** — mai phet**A little spicy** — phet nit noi**Vegetarian / vegan** — mangsawirat / jay**No fish sauce** — mai sai nam pla**The bill, please** — check bin**Water** — nam plao**Cheers!** — chon kaew!**I'm allergic to...** — phae...

TIME & SMALL TALK

Today / tomorrow — wan ni / phrung ni**How are you?** — sabai dee mai?**I'm well** — sabai dee**Beautiful** — suay**Friend** — phuean**Good luck** — chok dee

EMERGENCIES

Help! — chuay duay!**Hospital** — rong phayaban**Police** — tamruat**I'm lost** — chan long thang**Call a doctor** — riak mor

SAY IT WITH A SMILE

*Thai is tonal, so don't worry about perfection — a warm 'sawatdee khrap/kha' opens every door.**Men end politely with 'khrap', women with 'kha'.*

Resources & a few words

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TRUSTED & OFFICIAL

- Tourism Authority of Thailand — tourismthailand.org
- Immigration (visas) — immigration.go.th
- National parks — dnp.go.th
- Trains/buses/ferries — 12Go
- Tickets & tours — Klook / Kkday
- Rides & food — Grab / Bolt

INSIDER TIP

Save the Tourist Police number — 1155, in English — before you go. It's the fastest help in any dispute or loss.

A FEW WORDS OF THAI

Hello — sawatdee (khrap/kha)

Thank you — khop khun

How much? — tao rai?

Delicious! — aroi!

Not spicy — mai phet

Where is...? — ...yu thi nai?

The bill — check bin

Good luck — chok dee

Men end with 'khrap', women with 'kha'.

LOCAL TIP

Bookmark the official sites before you fly — visa rules and park openings change, and the source of truth beats a forum thread.



Before-you-go checklists

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BEFORE YOU GO

- ☐ Passport valid 6 months
- ☐ Check visa exemption (immigration.go.th)
- ☐ Insurance — motorbike cover if riding
- ☐ Vaccines current (clinic 6–8 wks ahead)
- ☐ Flights & first/last night booked
- ☐ Int'l Driving Permit (if driving)
- ☐ eSIM / SIM arranged
- ☐ Offline maps + document copies

FIRST-AID KIT

- ☐ Rehydration salts
- ☐ Anti-diarrhoeals
- ☐ Antiseptic & plasters
- ☐ Repellent & after-bite
- ☐ Personal meds + prescription

PACKING (TROPICAL)

- ☐ Light, modest clothes for temples
- ☐ Swimwear + sarong
- ☐ Sandals + trainers
- ☐ Rain jacket / poncho
- ☐ Reef-safe sunscreen + hat
- ☐ DEET repellent
- ☐ Universal adapter + power bank
- ☐ Reusable water bottle

DOCUMENTS TO CARRY

- ☐ Passport + copies
- ☐ Visa / proof of onward travel
- ☐ Insurance details
- ☐ Licence + IDP
- ☐ A few passport photos

LOCAL TIP

Print this page, or screenshot it to your phone — your pre-flight ritual in a single glance.



ONE LAST THING

Go slowly, see deeply

If there's one idea to carry into Thailand, it's this: resist the urge to see everything. The travellers who fall hardest for this country are the ones who slow down — who spend a third morning at the same coffee stall until the owner knows their order, who take the long road over the loop, who say yes to the invitation they didn't plan for.

Eat the thing you can't name. Learn the ten words. Give way to the smiles. Thailand will meet you more than halfway.

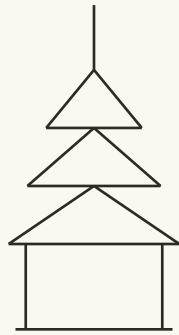
A FEW GOOD RESOURCES

- Tourism Authority of Thailand — tourismthailand.org
- 12Go — trains, buses & ferries
- Richard Barrow — long-running Thailand blog
- Grab / Bolt — rides & food
- Google Maps (offline) + Translate (Thai)
- Your travel insurer's 24-hour line

LOCAL TIP

Tear yourself away from the itinerary at least once. The afternoon you didn't plan is usually the one you'll remember.





Chok dee

Good luck, and travel gently.



THE SLOW ATLAS · RENNES, FRANCE